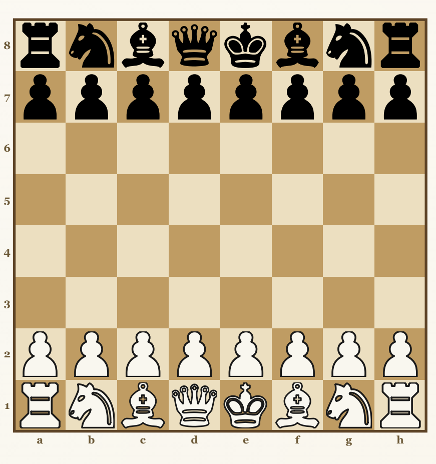
THE ROYAL GAME

# CHESS

*Rules of Play*

♚ ♛ ♜ ♝ ♞ ♟



✦ ✦ ✦

*A timeless contest of two minds — pure skill, no luck — fought across sixty-four squares for the fate of a king.*

| 2 | ALL | 64 | 32 |
|---|---|---|---|
| PLAYERS | AGES | SQUARES | PIECES |

## I The Object of the Game

*Trap the enemy king.*

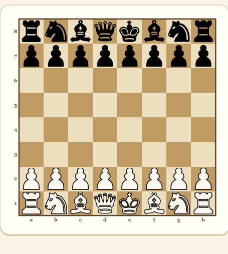
Chess is a battle between two armies — **White** and **Black** — across a board of 64 squares. Your goal is to **checkmate** your opponent's king: to attack it in such a way that it cannot escape capture.

**White always moves first**, after which the players alternate, making one move per turn. You must move on your turn — passing is not allowed. A game is won by delivering checkmate; it may also end in a draw, or by a player resigning.

**♚ Checkmate wins the game**
When a king is under attack (in **check**) and has no legal way to escape, it is **checkmate** — the game ends at once and the player whose king is trapped loses. The king is never actually captured; the game simply ends.

## II The Board & Starting Position

*Set the stage before the first move.*



The board is an **8 × 8 grid** of alternating light and dark squares. The columns (**files**) are lettered `a`–`h`; the rows (**ranks**) are numbered `1`–`8`, so every square has a name like `e4`.

**Place the board** so that each player has a **light square in the right-hand corner** ("light on the right").

On the rank nearest you, set the back row in order: **Rook, Knight, Bishop, Queen, King, Bishop, Knight, Rook.** Fill the rank in front entirely with **pawns**.

**Two handy reminders**
**"Queen on her own colour."** The white queen starts on a light square (d1), the black queen on a dark square (d8) — so the queens face each other, as do the kings. If your queen is on the wrong colour, the board is turned the wrong way.

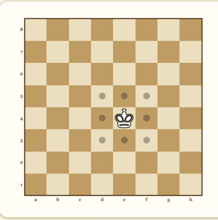
## III How the Pieces Move

*Each piece travels in its own way.*

On your turn you move **one piece** to an empty square, or **capture** an enemy piece by moving onto its square and removing it from the board. A few rules apply to everyone:

- You may never move onto a square occupied by **your own** piece, and only one piece may stand on a square.
- Except for the knight, pieces **cannot jump** — their path must be clear.
- You may never make a move that leaves **your own king in check**.

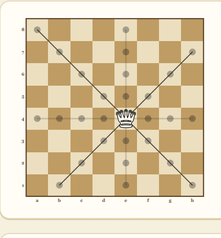
*In the diagrams below, a ● marks a square the piece can move to; a ○ marks an enemy that can be captured.*



### ♚ King

PRICELESS

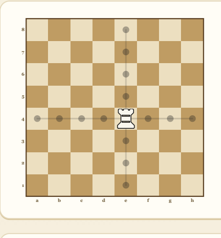
The king moves **one square** in any direction — horizontally, vertically, or diagonally. He is the most important piece: he can never move onto a square attacked by the enemy, and he can never be captured. The king also has a special move with a rook, called **castling** (see §IV).



### ♛ Queen

≈ 9 POINTS

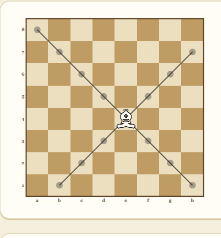
The queen is the most powerful piece. She moves **any number of squares** in a straight line — along a rank, a file, or a diagonal — in a single move, until blocked.



### ♜ Rook

≈ 5 POINTS

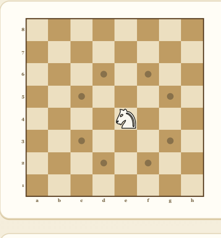
The rook moves **any number of squares** in a straight line along a **rank or file** (horizontally or vertically). It also partners with the king when castling.



### ♝ Bishop

≈ 3 POINTS

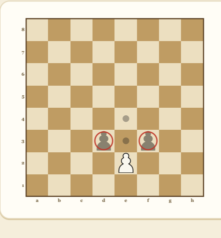
The bishop moves **any number of squares diagonally**. Because it travels only on diagonals, each bishop stays forever on its starting colour — every player has one light-squared and one dark-squared bishop.



### ♞ Knight

≈ 3 POINTS

The knight moves in an **"L" shape**: two squares along a rank or file, then one square at a right angle. It is the only piece that may **leap over** other pieces, and it always lands on a square of the opposite colour to the one it left.



### ♟ Pawn

≈ 1 POINT

The pawn advances **one square straight forward** — or **two squares** on its very first move. It never moves backward. Uniquely, it **captures differently from how it moves**: one square **diagonally forward** (the red rings). Pawns also have two special powers — **en passant** and **promotion** (see §IV).

### Relative value of the pieces

These rough point values help you judge whether a trade is fair. They are a guide, not a rule — position often matters more than material.

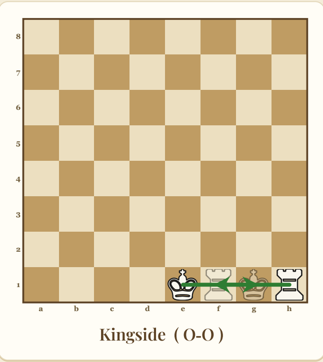
| PIECE | VALUE | MOVES |
|---|---|---|
| ♟ Pawn | 1 | One square forward; captures diagonally |
| ♞ Knight | 3 | "L" shape; jumps over pieces |
| ♝ Bishop | 3 | Diagonals, any distance |
| ♜ Rook | 5 | Ranks & files, any distance |
| ♛ Queen | 9 | Any straight line, any distance |
| ♚ King | ∞ | One square any direction; must be kept safe |

## IV Special Moves

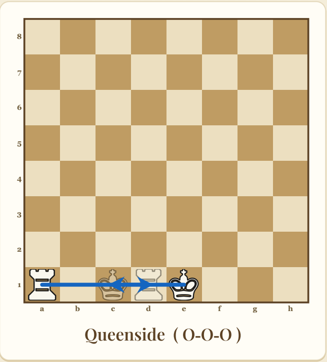
*Three moves every player must know.*

### Castling — tuck your king to safety

Once per game, the king may make a leap with one of his rooks: the **king moves two squares toward the rook**, and that **rook jumps to the square the king passed over**. It is the only move in which two pieces move at once, and the only time the king moves more than one square.



Kingside ( O-O )

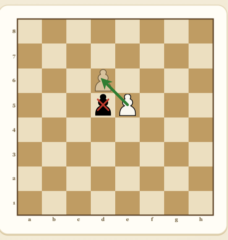


Queenside ( O-O-O )

You may castle only if **all** of these are true:

- Neither the **king** nor the **chosen rook** has moved yet this game.
- There are **no pieces between** the king and that rook.
- The king is **not in check**, and does **not pass through or land on** any square attacked by an enemy piece.

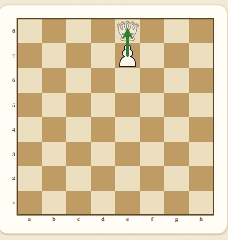
### En passant — "in passing"



When an enemy pawn uses its two-square first move to dash **past** a square your pawn is attacking — landing right beside yours — you may capture it **as if it had moved only one square**.

Your pawn moves diagonally to the skipped square (the green arrow) and the enemy pawn is removed (the red ✕). This capture is allowed **only on the very next move** — the chance is lost if you play anything else first.

### Promotion — a pawn's reward



A pawn that reaches the **far side of the board** (the 8th rank for White, the 1st for Black) is immediately **promoted** — exchanged for a **Queen, Rook, Bishop, or Knight** of its own colour. The new piece takes effect at once.

Almost everyone chooses a queen, the strongest piece — so you can have **two or more queens** on the board at the same time.

## V Check, Checkmate & Stalemate

*The heart of the game.*

### Check

When a king is attacked by an enemy piece, it is **in check**. You must get out of check **immediately**, using one of three replies:

- **Move** the king to a safe square;
- **Block** the check by placing a piece between the king and the attacker; or
- **Capture** the attacking piece.

You may never leave — or move — your own king into check. If a move would do so, it is simply illegal.

**♚ Checkmate — the game is won**
If a king is in check and **none** of the three replies is possible, it is **checkmate**. The game ends instantly and the side that delivered mate wins.

**½ Stalemate — the game is drawn**
If the player to move has **no legal move** but their king is **not in check**, the game is a **stalemate** — a draw. A lone, trapped-but-unchecked king is a common way to let a winning position slip away, so take care when your opponent is down to very little.

## VI Other Ways a Game Is Drawn

*Not every game has a winner.*

**Stalemate**
The side to move has no legal move and is not in check (see §V).

**The fifty-move rule**
If fifty consecutive moves by each side pass with no capture and no pawn move, the game may be drawn.

**Insufficient material**
Neither side has enough force to checkmate — for example king vs king, or king and a single bishop or knight vs king.

**Agreement**
The two players simply agree that the game is a draw and shake hands.

**Threefold repetition**
The exact same position occurs three times, with the same player to move — either side may then claim a draw.

**Dead position**
No sequence of legal moves could ever lead to checkmate for either side.

## VII Reading & Writing the Moves

*Algebraic notation, at a glance.*

Every square has a name from its file and rank (`a1` to `h8`). A move is written as the **piece's letter** plus the **square it lands on**. Pawns have no letter — just the square.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Piece letters** | `K` King `Q` Queen `R` Rook `B` Bishop `N` Knight *(N, so as not to clash with the King)* |
| **A move** | `Nf3` = knight to f3 · `e4` = pawn to e4 |
| **Capture** | `x` — `Bxe5` = bishop takes on e5 · `exd5` = e-pawn takes d5 |
| **Check / mate** | `+` check · `#` checkmate |
| **Castling** | `O-O` kingside · `O-O-O` queenside |
| **Promotion** | `e8=Q` = pawn to e8, promoting to a queen |

**A game begins like this:**
`1.` e4 e5 `2.` Nf3 Nc6 `3.` Bb5
*Each numbered pair is one move by White then one by Black: pawns step into the centre, knights and a bishop come into play.*

## VIII Good to Know

*Etiquette, fair play, and a few first principles.*

### Rules of conduct

- **Touch-move.** If you touch one of your pieces, you must move it (if it has a legal move); if you touch an enemy piece, you must capture it (if you legally can). To merely straighten a piece, first say **"I adjust"** (*j'adoube*).
- **Let go.** A move is complete the moment you release the piece — you cannot take it back.
- **White moves first**, and players alternate throughout.
- A game may also end when a player **resigns**, or — in games with a clock — when a player's **time runs out**.

**First principles for a strong start**
Fight for the **centre** with your pawns; **develop** your knights and bishops toward the middle; **castle early** to safeguard your king; try not to move the same piece twice in the opening, and don't bring your queen out too soon.

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*Now set up the board — White to move.*

*Chess · Rules of Play · sixty-four squares, a lifetime of games*